

ATENU.ORG EDUCATION REPORT · 2024/25

Ethiopia's Education System in 2024/25: The Numbers Are Getting Worse — Here's What You Need to Know

A year-on-year analysis of the ESAA 2024/25 reveals declining completion rates, rising dropout, and a widening gap between access and outcomes

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The 2024/25 Education Statistics Annual Abstract marks the final year of Ethiopia's ESDP VI — the five-year education plan that was supposed to transform the system by now. The verdict? Ethiopia still gets children into classrooms, but the pipeline from Grade 1 to Grade 12 is leaking faster than ever. At Atenu.org, we've analyzed both the 2024/25 and 2023/24 reports to show you what's changed, what's worsened, and what it means if you're a student, parent, or educator navigating this system today.

Important note on data comparability: The 2024/25 report excludes Amhara region (where schooling has been disrupted for two consecutive years) but re-includes Tigray. The 2023/24 report excluded *both* Tigray and most of Amhara. This means year-on-year changes reflect both real trends *and* changes in which regions are counted. We flag this throughout the article where it matters.

59.8%

PRE-PRIMARY GER

98.1%

PRIMARY+MIDDLE
GER

30.4%

SECONDARY GER

12.8%

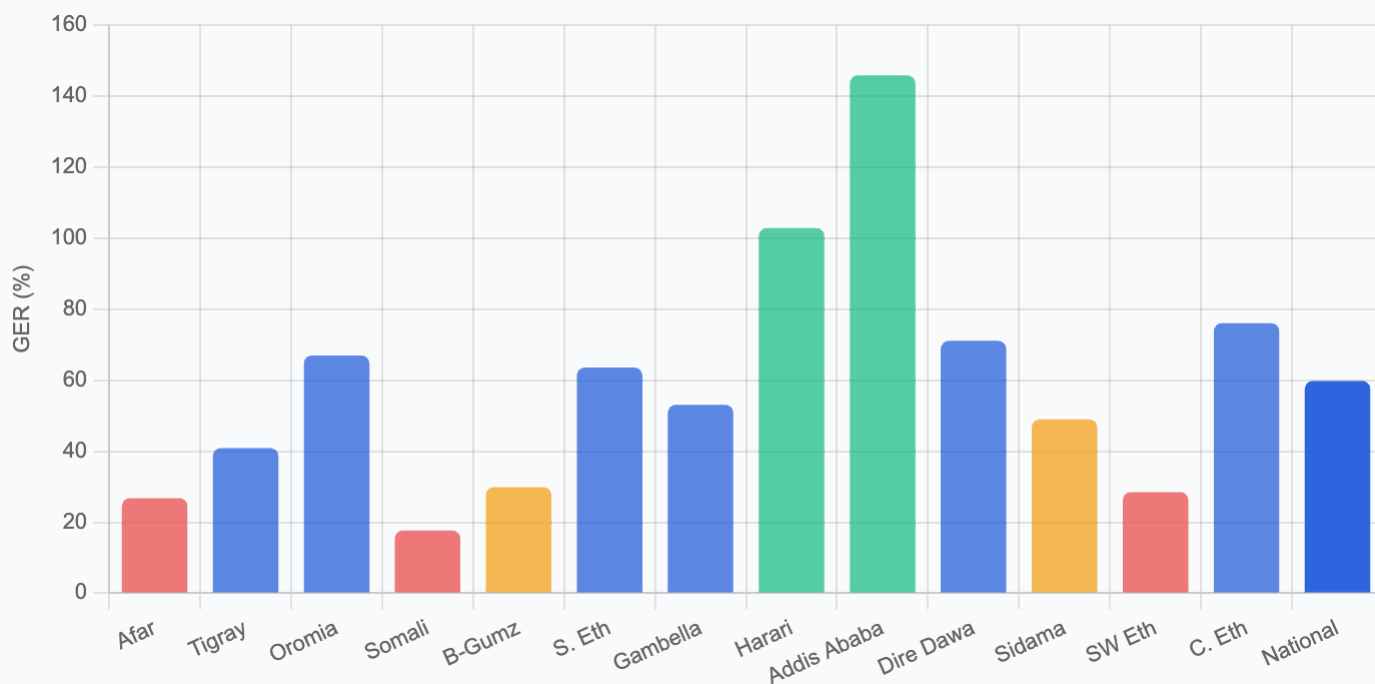
G8 GRADUATES PER
COHORT

1. Pre-Primary Education: Modest Gains in Early Access

Ethiopia enrolled nearly 4 million children in pre-primary education in 2024/25, pushing the national GER to 59.8% — a two percentage point increase from 57.8% in 2023/24. More impressively, the Net Enrolment Rate (NER) jumped to 58.1%, up from 45.2% the prior year. This dramatic NER rise suggests more children are enrolling at the correct age (4–6 years), though the re-inclusion of Tigray data also contributes to the change.

The number of kindergarten schools grew from 14,909 to 18,209 — a remarkable 22% increase in a single year, with 72% government-owned. But the national pre-primary GER still falls short of the ESDP VI target of 73–74%, and regional gaps remain extreme: Addis Ababa (145.9%) and Harari (102.9%) far exceed 100%, while Somali (17.7%) and Afar (26.8%) remain far behind.

Pre-Primary GER by Region, 2024/25



Source: MoE ESAA 2024/25, Table 2.1

Year-on-Year: Pre-Primary Education

GER: 57.8% → 59.8% (+2.0pp)

NER: 45.2% → 58.1% (+12.9pp)

KG Schools: 14,909 → 18,209 (+22%)

GPI: 0.96 → 0.95 (stable, near-parity)

Pre-primary is one of the few areas showing consistent improvement. The NER surge is particularly encouraging — it means more children are starting at the right age.

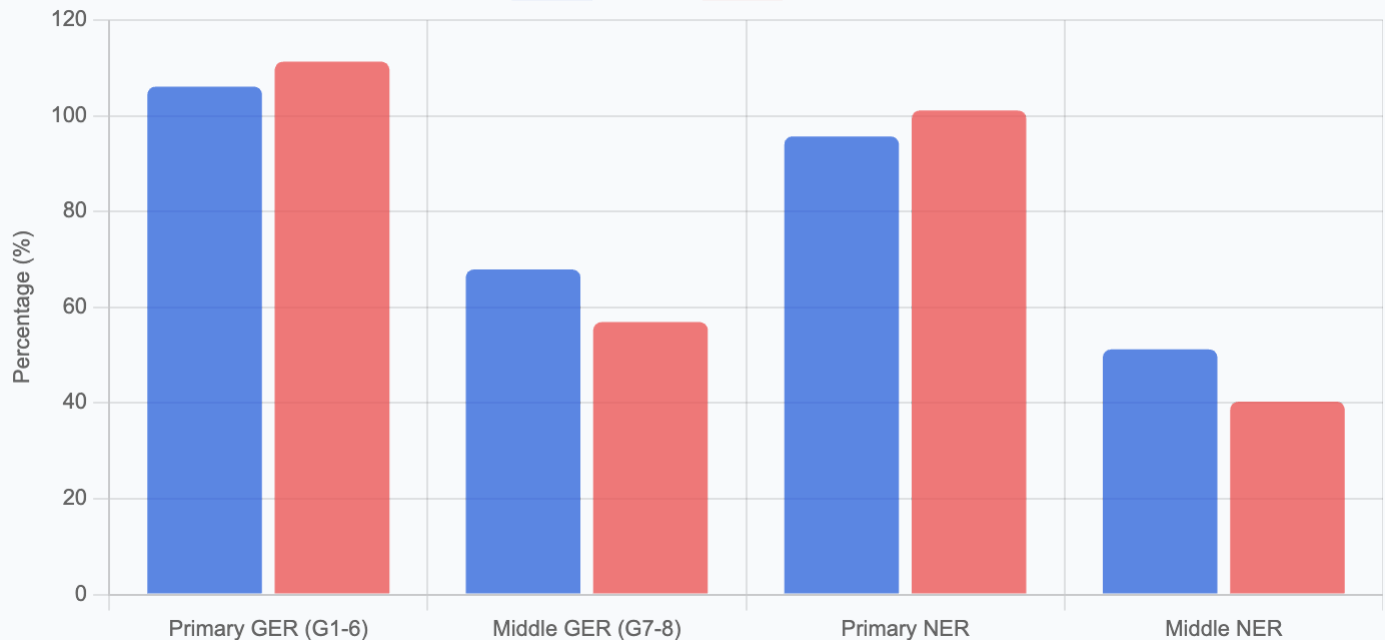
2. Primary & Middle School: Access Up, But the Middle School Gap Widens

Primary education (Grades 1–6) continues to show strong enrolment numbers with a national GER of 111.3%, up from 106.1%. The system is absorbing more children, including over-age learners. The Apparent Intake Ratio (AIR) for Grade 1 stands at 149.8% — meaning nearly 50% more children enter Grade 1 than there are 7-year-olds in the population. While this signals near-universal access to first grade, it also confirms a persistent problem of over-age entry.

The real concern is what happens after primary school. Middle school (Grades 7–8) GER dropped to 56.9%, down sharply from 67.9% in 2023/24. The NER for middle school is even more alarming at just 40.3%. Only four out of every ten children of middle-school age are actually enrolled in Grades 7–8 at the right time.

Primary vs. Middle School GER: 2023/24 vs. 2024/25

2023/242024/25



Source: MoE ESAA 2023/24 & 2024/25

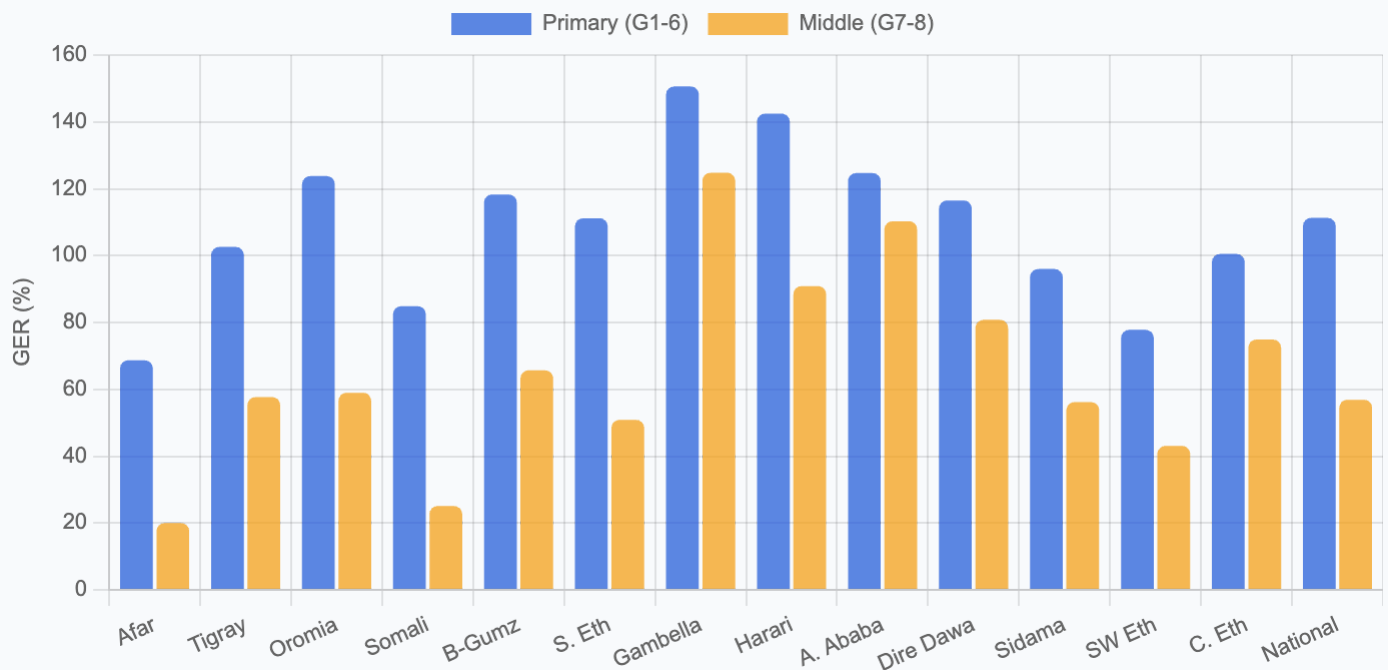
Indicator	2023/24	2024/25	Change
Primary GER (G1-6)	106.1%	111.3%	+5.2pp
Middle GER (G7-8)	67.9%	56.9%	-11.0pp
Primary NER (G1-6)	95.7%	101.1%	+5.4pp
Middle NER (G7-8)	51.2%	40.3%	-10.9pp
GER Grades 1-8	96.9%	98.1%	+1.2pp
NER Grades 1-8	88.4%	91.9%	+3.5pp

The Primary-to-Middle gap is widening. In 2023/24, primary GER was 1.56× the middle school GER. In 2024/25, it's 1.96× — meaning the transition cliff between Grade 6 and Grade 7 is getting steeper, not flatter.

Regional GER: A Country of Contrasts

At the primary level, Gambella (150.6%), Harari (142.5%), and Benishangul-Gumz (118.3%) record extremely high GER values — signaling heavy over-age enrolment. Meanwhile, Afar (68.7%) and Somali (84.9%) still struggle to reach universal primary access. The regional spread at middle school level is even wider: Gambella leads at 124.8% while Afar sits at just 20.0%.

Primary vs. Middle School GER by Region, 2024/25



Source: MoE ESAA 2024/25, Table 3.3

Classroom Conditions

The national Pupil-Teacher Ratio (PTR) for Grades 1–8 slightly increased from 35.5 to 37.8, reflecting faster student growth than teacher recruitment. The Pupil-Section Ratio (effective class size) is 54.2 at the primary level — well above the national standard of 50. Regions like Oromia (60.0), Sidama (59.6), and South Ethiopia (52.7) pack the most students per section.

The PTR for secondary improved significantly from 22.6 to 20.7, as the number of secondary students declined while teacher numbers held steady.

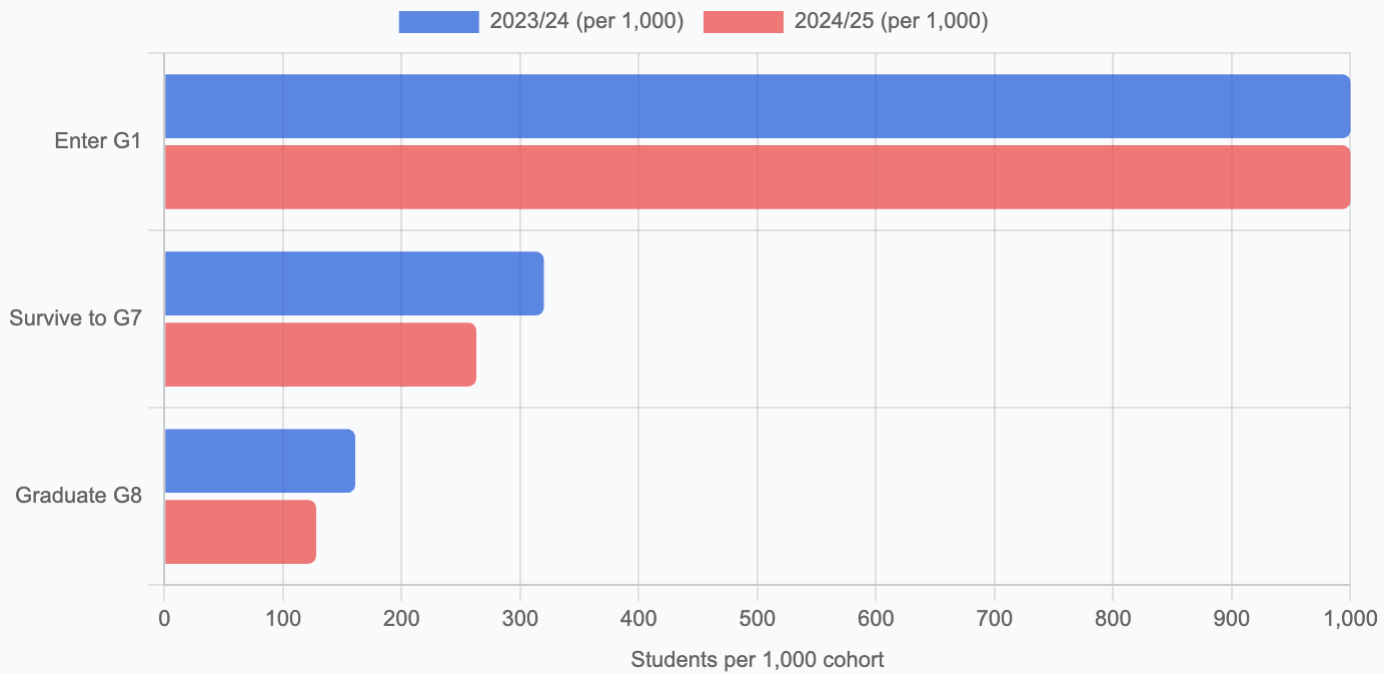
3. Internal Efficiency: The Numbers Every Parent Should Know

This section matters most. Internal efficiency measures how well the system retains students and moves them toward completion. In 2024/25, nearly every efficiency indicator worsened compared to the previous year.

The headline number: Of every 1,000 children who enter Grade 1, only 263 survive to Grade 7, and just 128 eventually graduate from Grade 8. This means **87.2% of each cohort fails to complete**

primary and middle school — up from 83.9% the previous year. The efficiency coefficient is just 22.8%.

The Education Funnel: 2023/24 vs. 2024/25 (per 1,000 Grade 1 entrants)

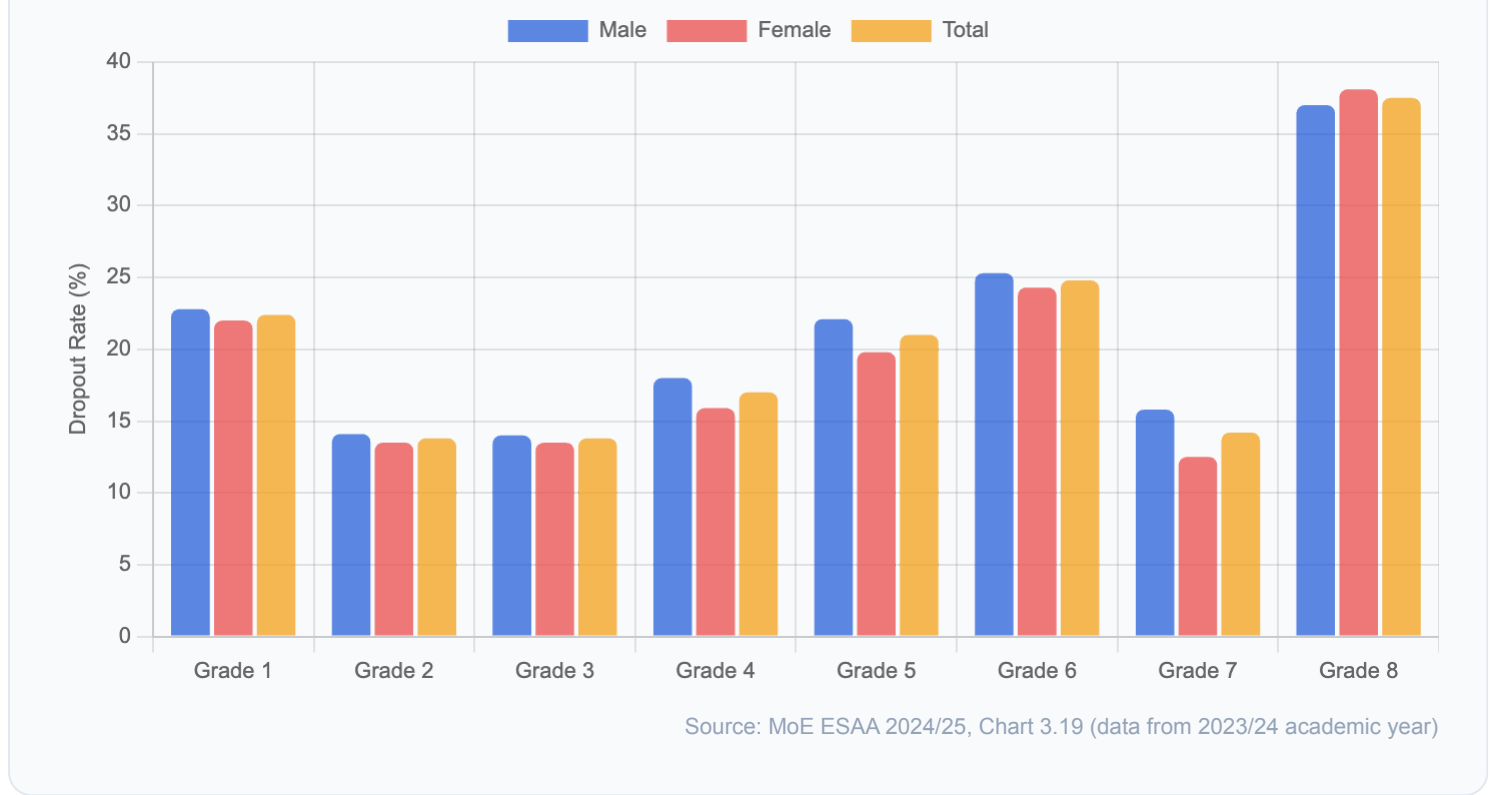


Source: MoE ESAA 2023/24 & 2024/25, Reconstructed Cohort Analysis

Dropout: Rising Across Every Level

The national dropout rate for Grades 1–8 rose to 20.5%, up from 17.9%. Grade 1 remains the most critical leak point, with 22.4% of first-graders dropping out before reaching Grade 2. Grade 8 sees the highest absolute dropout at 37.5%, as students leave the system at the transition to secondary education.

Dropout Rate by Grade (National), 2023/24



Regionally, Afar (26.9%), Sidama (25.9%), and South West Ethiopia (25.8%) have the highest overall dropout rates. Addis Ababa stands out with the lowest at just 0.5%, demonstrating that urban systems with better infrastructure can dramatically reduce student loss.

Completion Rates: The Most Alarming Decline

Completion rates have deteriorated significantly. The Grade 6 completion rate fell from 67.5% to 59.5%, and Grade 8 completion dropped from 60.2% to 50.4%. These are not small movements — they represent hundreds of thousands of additional children leaving the system before reaching meaningful educational milestones.

Efficiency Indicator	2023/24	2024/25	ESDP VI Target	Change
Grade 1 dropout rate	20.9%	22.4%	15%	+1.5pp
Grades 1-8 dropout rate	17.9%	20.5%	—	+2.6pp
Grades 1-8 repetition rate	4.4%	4.3%	1%	-0.1pp
Survival to Grade 7	32.0%	26.3%	50%	-5.7pp
G8 graduates per 1,000 cohort	161	128	—	-33
Completion rate, Grade 6	67.5%	59.5%	90-93%	-8.0pp
Completion rate, Grade 8	60.2%	50.4%	75-77%	-9.8pp

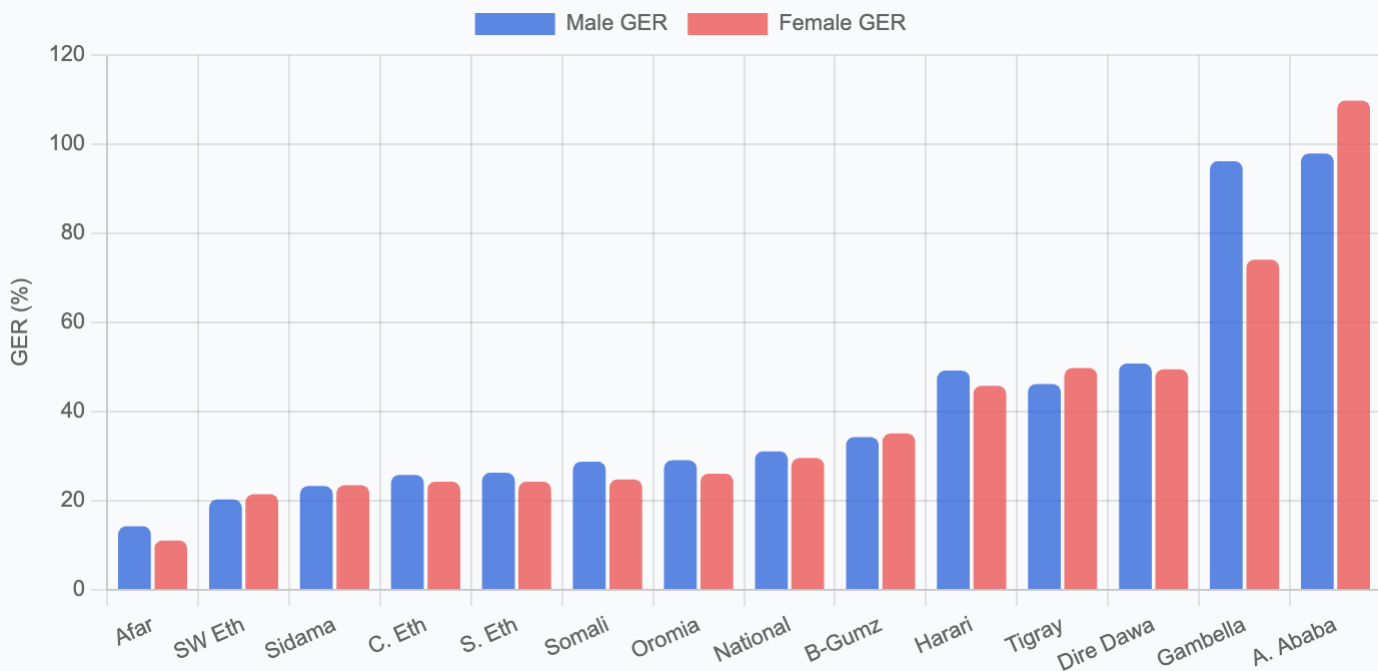
Year-on-Year: Internal Efficiency — A Clear Deterioration

Nearly every internal efficiency metric worsened. The survival rate to Grade 7 fell by 5.7 percentage points, and the number of Grade 8 graduates per starting cohort of 1,000 dropped from 161 to 128. Repetition is the lone exception, declining marginally. The overall picture: more children enter school, but fewer make it through. This is not just a data caveat — even accounting for Tigray’s re-inclusion, the trend lines are moving in the wrong direction.

4. Secondary Education: Fewer Students, Deeper Inequity

Secondary education (Grades 9–12) recorded a national GER of just 30.4%, down from 36.6% in 2023/24. The NER tells an even starker story: only 22.9% of 15-to-18 year olds are enrolled in secondary school. This represents a reversal after eight years of steady growth — secondary GER peaked at 45.6% in 2021/22 before declining for three consecutive years.

Secondary Education GER by Region, 2024/25



Source: MoE ESAA 2024/25, Table 4.1

Only Addis Ababa (104.1%) and Gambella (85.4%) exceed 50% secondary GER. Most regions sit between 20–35%, and Afar (12.8%), South West Ethiopia (20.9%), and South Ethiopia (25.3%) are at the bottom. For female students, the picture is even bleaker: the national female secondary GER is 29.6%, compared to 31.1% for males.

Year-on-Year: Secondary Education

GER (G9-12): 36.6% → 30.4% **(-6.2pp)**

NER (G9-12): ~25.0% → 22.9% **(-2.1pp)**

GPI: 0.95 (target of 0.92 exceeded — **one of few ESDP VI successes**)

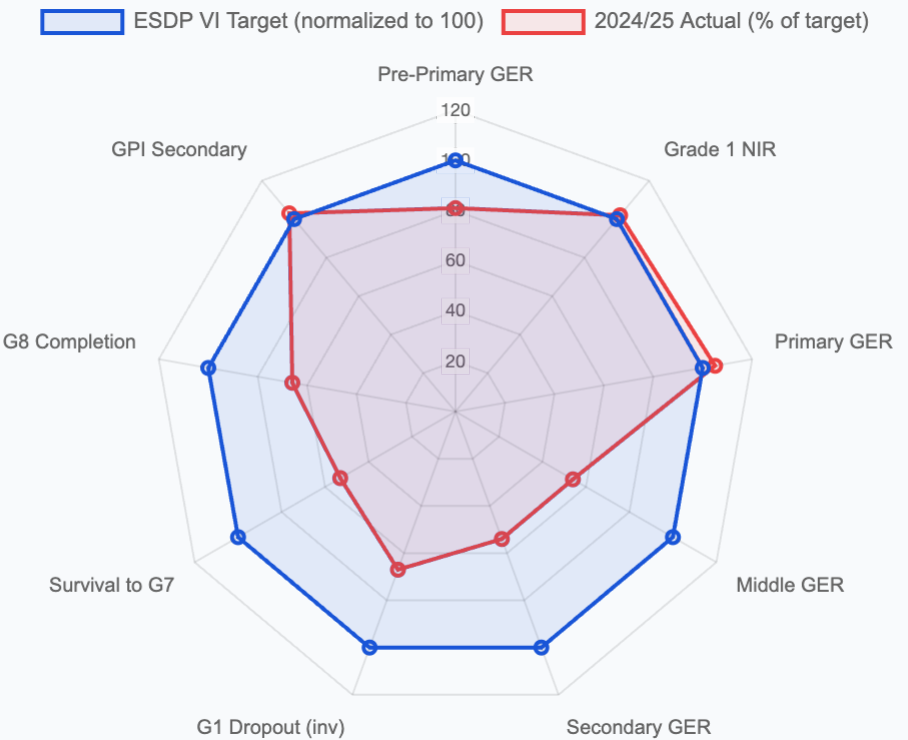
PTR: 22.6 → 20.7 **(improved, below the standard of 40)**

The decline in secondary GER is concerning because it coincides with rising dropout at the primary level — fewer students are making it to Grade 9 to begin with.

5. ESDP VI Final Scorecard: How Did Ethiopia Do?

2024/25 is the final year of ESDP VI (2020/21 – 2024/25). The plan set ambitious targets for access, quality, equity, and efficiency. Here’s how the actuals compare to targets:

ESDP VI Targets vs. 2024/25 Actuals

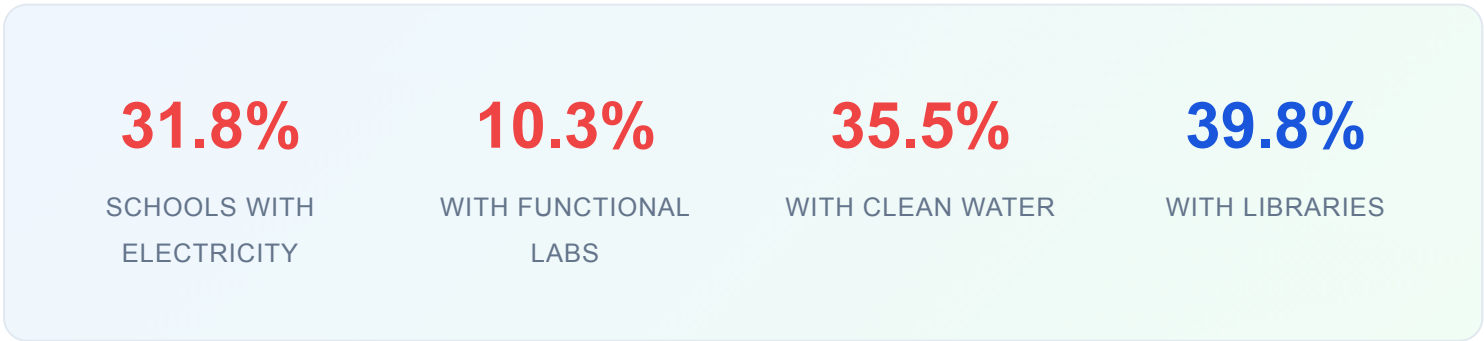


Indicator	2018/19 Baseline	ESDP VI Target	2024/25 Actual	Met?
Pre-Primary GER (F/M)	40/41	73/74	58.1/61.4	No
Grade 1 NIR	88/97	95/99	94.9/103.4	Partial
Grades 1-6 GER	109/121	104/109	105.9/116.5	Yes
Grades 7-8 GER	106/118	102/108	55.8/58.1	No
Grades 9-12 GER	30/34	55/57	29.6/31.1	No
Grade 1 dropout	25%	15%	22.4%	No
Survival to Grade 7	31/29	50/50	27.7/25.2	No
Completion, Grade 8	60/64	75/77	49.6/51.2	No
GPI, Secondary	0.87	0.92	0.95	Yes

The scorecard tells a tale of two systems. Access at the primary level (Grades 1–6) met or exceeded targets — Ethiopia successfully gets children into school. But every indicator measuring retention, completion, or secondary access fell far short. The system’s challenge has decisively shifted from “getting children enrolled” to “keeping them learning.”

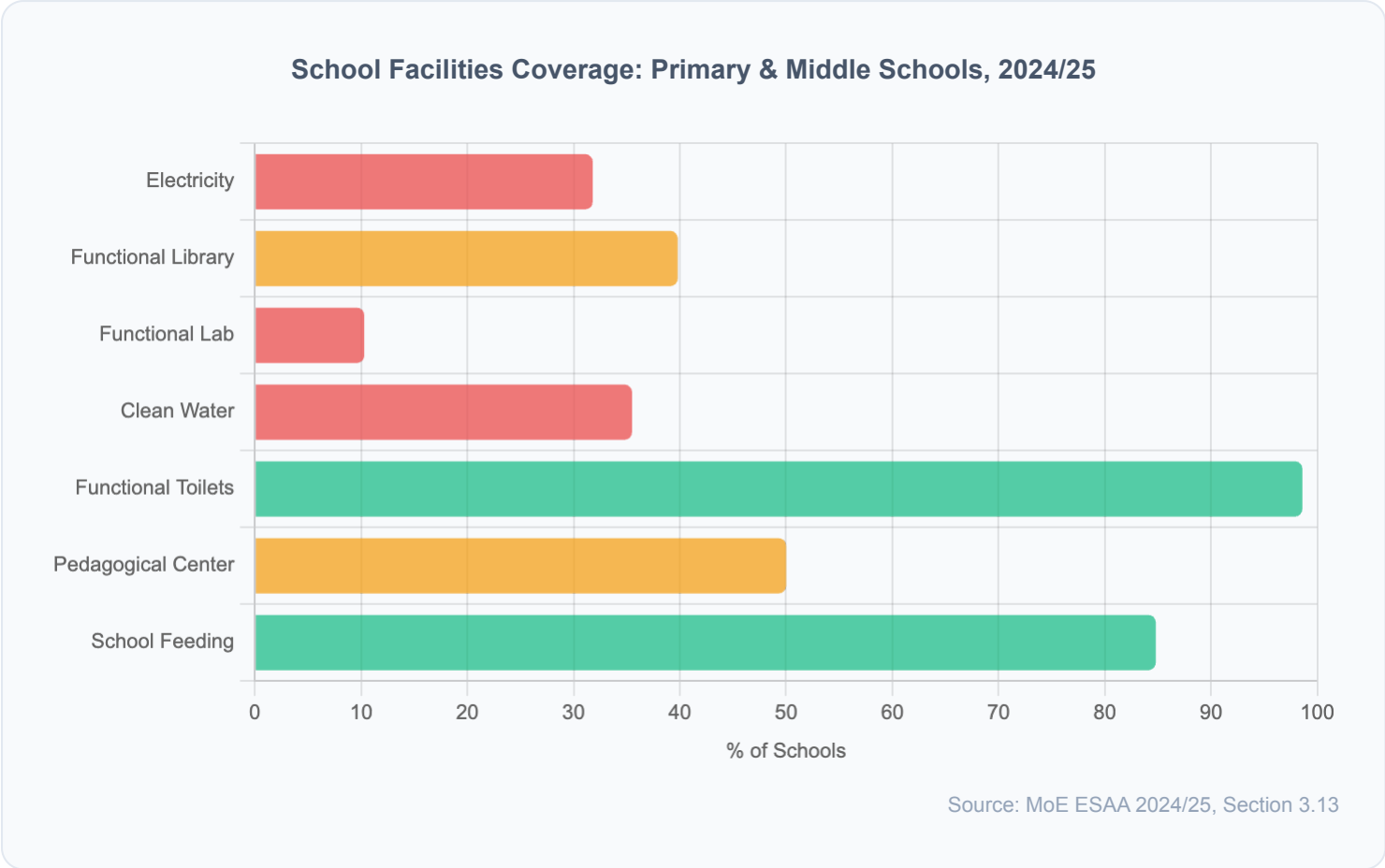
6. School Facilities & Quality: The Infrastructure Gap

Learning happens in classrooms, and the condition of those classrooms matters. The 2024/25 data reveals severe infrastructure deficits across Ethiopia’s 30,522 primary and middle schools:



Only 31.8% of primary and middle schools have electricity. Just 10.3% have functional laboratories — meaning nine out of ten students learn science without ever conducting an experiment. Only 35.5% of

schools have functional drinking water access. Textbook-to-pupil ratios remain critically low at 1:5 for English and Mathematics at the primary level, meaning one textbook is shared among five students.



The school inspection results paint a complementary picture: of 5,308 schools inspected, only 17.7% met Level 3 or above (the standard), while 16% were rated Level 1 (requiring significant improvement). These infrastructure and quality deficits directly impact learning outcomes and contribute to dropout.

7. Gender & Equity: The Bright Spot

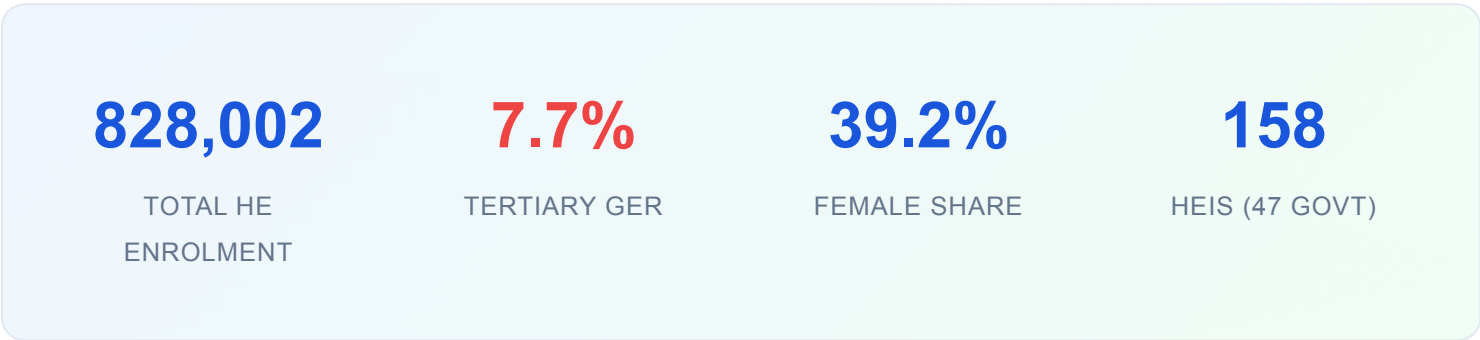
If there is one area where ESDP VI can claim success, it is gender equity. The Gender Parity Index (GPI) at the secondary level reached 0.95 — exceeding the target of 0.92 and representing a significant jump from the 0.87 baseline. At primary and middle levels, GPI sits at 0.91 and 0.96 respectively.

A success story: The GPI for secondary education improved from 0.87 (2018/19) to 0.95 (2024/25), indicating that for every 100 boys enrolled in secondary school, 95 girls are enrolled. While not yet perfect parity, this is meaningful progress driven by targeted programs for girls’ education, school feeding, and community mobilization.

However, gender equity varies enormously by region. Somali (GPI 0.77 at primary) and Afar (GPI 0.81) still show strong male bias, while Addis Ababa (1.12 at secondary) and Tigray (1.08) now show female advantage. The pastoral/emerging regions remain the frontier for girls’ education.

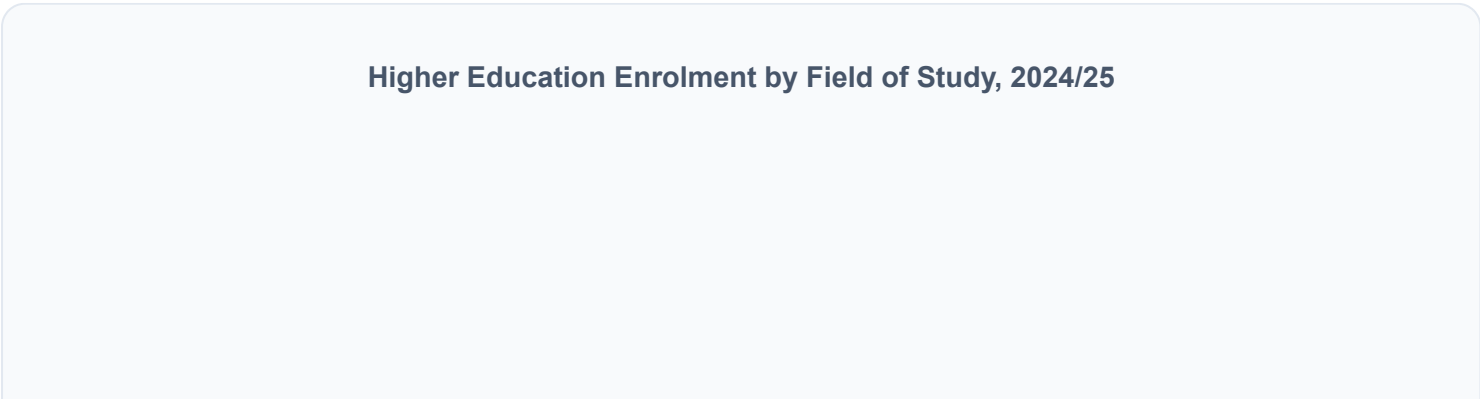
8. Higher Education: What Are Students Studying at University?

Ethiopia’s 158 higher education institutions (47 government, 111 non-government) enrolled 828,002 students in 2024/25 — but with a tertiary Gross Enrolment Rate of just 7.7%, university remains a destination for a very select few. Among those who do make it, the choice of field tells a striking story about the country’s economic aspirations and structural constraints.

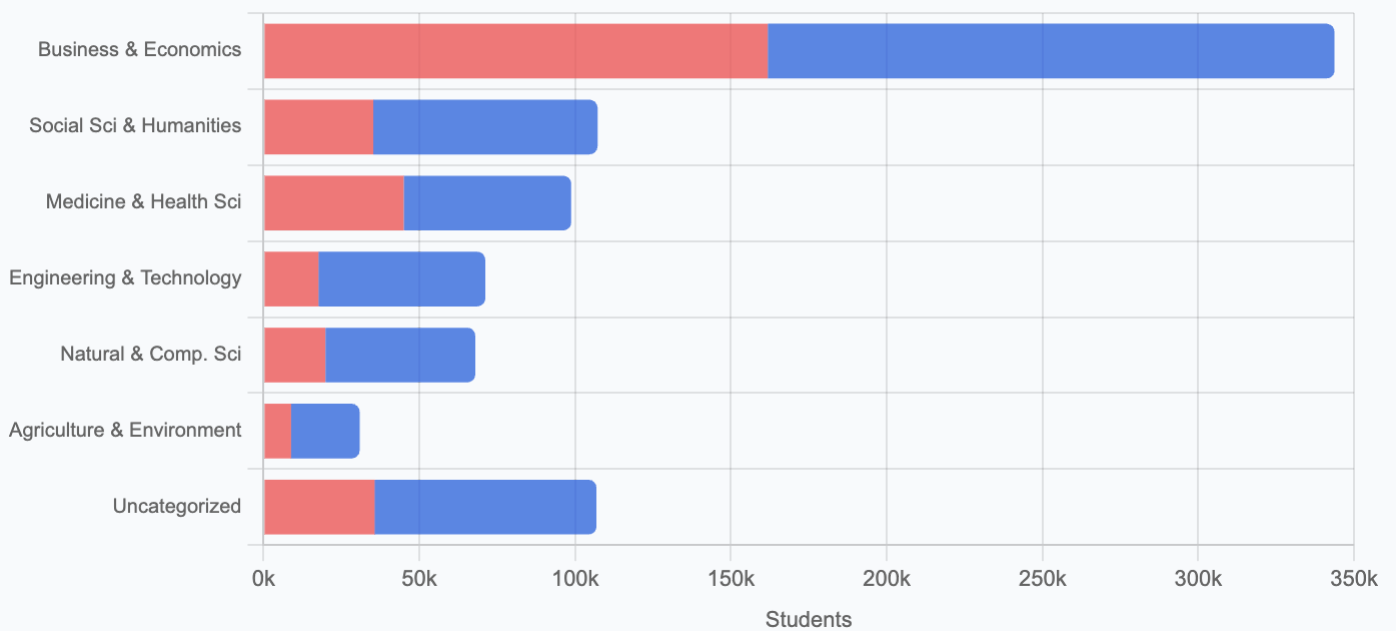


Business and Economics dominates, accounting for 41.5% of all higher education enrolment (343,729 students). This is driven overwhelmingly by non-government institutions, which enrol nearly 250,000 of these students — making private business programmes the single largest segment of Ethiopian higher education. It also has the highest female participation (47.1%), signalling growing gender inclusiveness in economically strategic fields.

Social Sciences and Humanities (12.9%) and Medicine and Health Science (12.1%) are the next largest fields. Health has a notably high female share (45.8%), indicating women’s strong preference for care-giving professions. In contrast, **STEM fields remain male-dominated**: Engineering and Technology (8.6% of enrolment, just 24.8% female) and Natural and Computational Science (8.2%, 29.2% female) together account for less than 17% of all university students.



Female Male



Source: MoE HESAA 2024/25, Table 4 — Enrolment by Local Band

The university pipeline problem: With only ~30% of the age group enrolled in secondary school and a tertiary GER of 7.7%, fewer than 8 in 100 young Ethiopians attend university. Of those who do, 4 in 10 study Business and Economics — often at private institutions — while critical STEM and agricultural fields that could drive economic transformation remain under-enrolled. Agriculture, which employs over 60% of the workforce, attracts just 3.7% of university students.

9. What This Means for Students and Parents

If you're a student or parent in Ethiopia, these numbers have real implications for your educational journey:

For primary school students: Getting into Grade 1 is easy — staying through Grade 8 is the challenge. Nationally, your chances of reaching Grade 7 from Grade 1 are roughly 1 in 4. If you are in Afar, Sidama, or South West Ethiopia, the odds are even lower. The most dangerous transitions are Grade 1 (22.4% dropout) and Grade 8 (37.5% dropout).

For secondary school students: If you've made it to Grade 9, you're already in a select group — only about 30% of your age group is enrolled. The transition from Grade 8 to Grade 9 is the single biggest filter in the system. Resources at the secondary level are generally better (PTR of 21, lower class sizes), but textbook shortages persist.

For Grade 12 exam takers: The national exam remains the defining gate to higher education. Competition is intense, and pass rates vary dramatically by region and stream. With less than a third of the age group even reaching secondary, those who do face an enormous responsibility — and opportunity.

For parents: The data makes a clear case for sustained engagement throughout your child's schooling. The risk of dropout is highest in Grade 1, Grades 5–6, and Grade 8. School feeding programs now cover 8 million students and can be a factor in school choice. Urban schools dramatically outperform rural ones on virtually every metric.

Atenu.org: Free Exam Preparation for Every Ethiopian Student

In a system where only 12.8% of each cohort completes Grade 8, and where textbook-to-pupil ratios sit at 1:5, access to quality study materials can make the difference. **Atenu.org** provides free, curriculum-aligned exam preparation for Grades 9–12 and the ESSLCE national exam — no login required, no fees, no barriers.

Our mission is built on the data in this article: if the system loses 87% of students before Grade 8, those who do reach secondary school deserve every possible tool to succeed. Atenu.org covers all Natural and Social Science stream subjects, with practice questions, past papers, and explanations designed specifically for the Ethiopian curriculum.

[Start Studying Free at Atenu.org →](#)

10. Looking Ahead: What Needs to Change

As Ethiopia enters its next education sector plan, the ESAA 2024/25 provides a clear diagnosis. The system has largely solved the access problem at the primary level, but it has not solved the retention problem, the quality problem, or the transition problem. Three priorities stand out:

First, fix the Grade 1 transition. One in five children drops out after their first year. This suggests children are entering school unprepared, over-aged, or in environments that cannot support them. Expanding quality pre-primary education — which showed real progress this year — is part of the answer.

Second, bridge the primary-to-middle gap. The GER cliff from 111.3% (primary) to 56.9% (middle) is the system’s most dramatic failure point. It reflects school infrastructure gaps (not enough middle schools), geographic barriers, and economic pressure on families.

Third, invest in school facilities. With only 31.8% of schools electrified, 10.3% with labs, and 35.5% with clean water, the physical environment of most Ethiopian schools is not conducive to learning. The textbook crisis (1 book per 5 students in core subjects) means most learning depends entirely on what teachers can deliver orally.

The EMIS digitalization completed in 2024/25, using AI and business intelligence for data collection and analysis, is a promising development that could improve evidence-based planning. But better data alone won’t keep students in school.

Atenu.org’s commitment: As these reports make clear, Ethiopian students face structural barriers that won’t disappear overnight. While we can’t build schools or hire teachers, we can ensure that every student who reaches Grades 9–12 has access to free, high-quality exam preparation materials. That’s the gap Atenu.org exists to fill — and it’s why we publish analyses like this one, to keep the education conversation grounded in data, not assumptions.

Methodology & Sources

All data in this article comes from the FDRE Ministry of Education’s *Education Statistics Annual Abstract 2024/25 (2017 E.C.)*, published October 2025, and the *ESAA 2023/24 (2016 E.C.)* for year-on-year comparisons. The Atenu.org Research Desk independently cross-referenced indicators across sections and flagged data comparability issues arising from regional coverage changes. Dropout and repetition data in the 2024/25 report reflect the 2023/24 academic year, as is standard practice. The reconstructed cohort analysis assumes a starting cohort of 1,000 pupils entering Grade 1.

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